GOA

A GOAN RECIPE FOR TROUBLE

A tribal minister leaves the Pramod Sawant regime red-faced with allegations of graft. What simmers beneath the surface is an unmet Adivasi manifesto

an event organised by the tribal welfare department and the United Tribal Association Alliance (UTAA) on May 25, when he veered off the script.

The department is getting "a large amount of taxpayer money" but not utilising it properly, he said. More scathingly, Gaude alleged, files of contractors were handled at the Shram Shakti Bhavan, and "something was taken" from them before they were processed.

A livid Sawant has vowed "appropriate action", and BJP state unit chief Damodar Naik confirmed this. But this isn't the first time the Sawant regime is getting hot Goan egg curry on its face. In March, ex-minister and BJP veteran Pandurang Madkaikar claimed he had to pay Rs 15-20 lakh to a minister to get his work done and that everyone was "busy counting money". Madkaikar, also a Hindu Gauda, recanted later. Gaude, too, is trying to, insisting that he has not said anything against Sawant. But punters are betting on his job lasting only till an imminent cabinet reshuffle.

Takeaways

- **BJP minister Govind Gaude says files move only after "something is taken"**
- **A tribal face, he has the support of pressure group UTAA, as also the Congress**
- **Ahead of 2027 assembly polls, BJP has to negotiate on demand for Scheduled Areas, political reservation**



AT ODDS Goa CM Pramod Sawant (left) and minister Govind Gaude

Thereby hangs a tale that can twist and turn. The UTAA, led by former MLA Prakash Velip, is openly backing Gaude. A tribal advocacy group, it has been pro-BJP for over a decade—but conditional to its demands being met. It's an old Adivasi manifesto that has tilted Goa politics: passage of the ST Political Reservation Bill, notification of Scheduled Areas, and a tribal advisory council.

Gaude's speech came at a tribute to two tribal youth slain in mob violence on May 25, 2011, while agitating for these demands. The tribal backlash had cost the Congress dear in the 2012 election, returning the BJP to power.

ADIVASI MANIFESTO

Not a segment to be trifled with, then, yet not big enough. Counting Hindus and Christians, tribals are about 10.23 per cent of Goa's population. North Goa has 56,606 tribals, South 92,669—or 7 and 14.5 per cent of local populations. That does not warrant Scheduled Areas, says Sawant. This live wish list feeds a script of unfulfilment, rife with characters encashing it. Gaude, seen to be close to CM aspirant and health minister Vishwajit Rane, has also faced fire for alleged graft in the Kala Academy. Retaining him would be a sign of weakness, but dropping him is dicey. Speaker Ramesh Tawadkar is handy as a rival tribal leader, close to Sawant. Await the next act. ■